



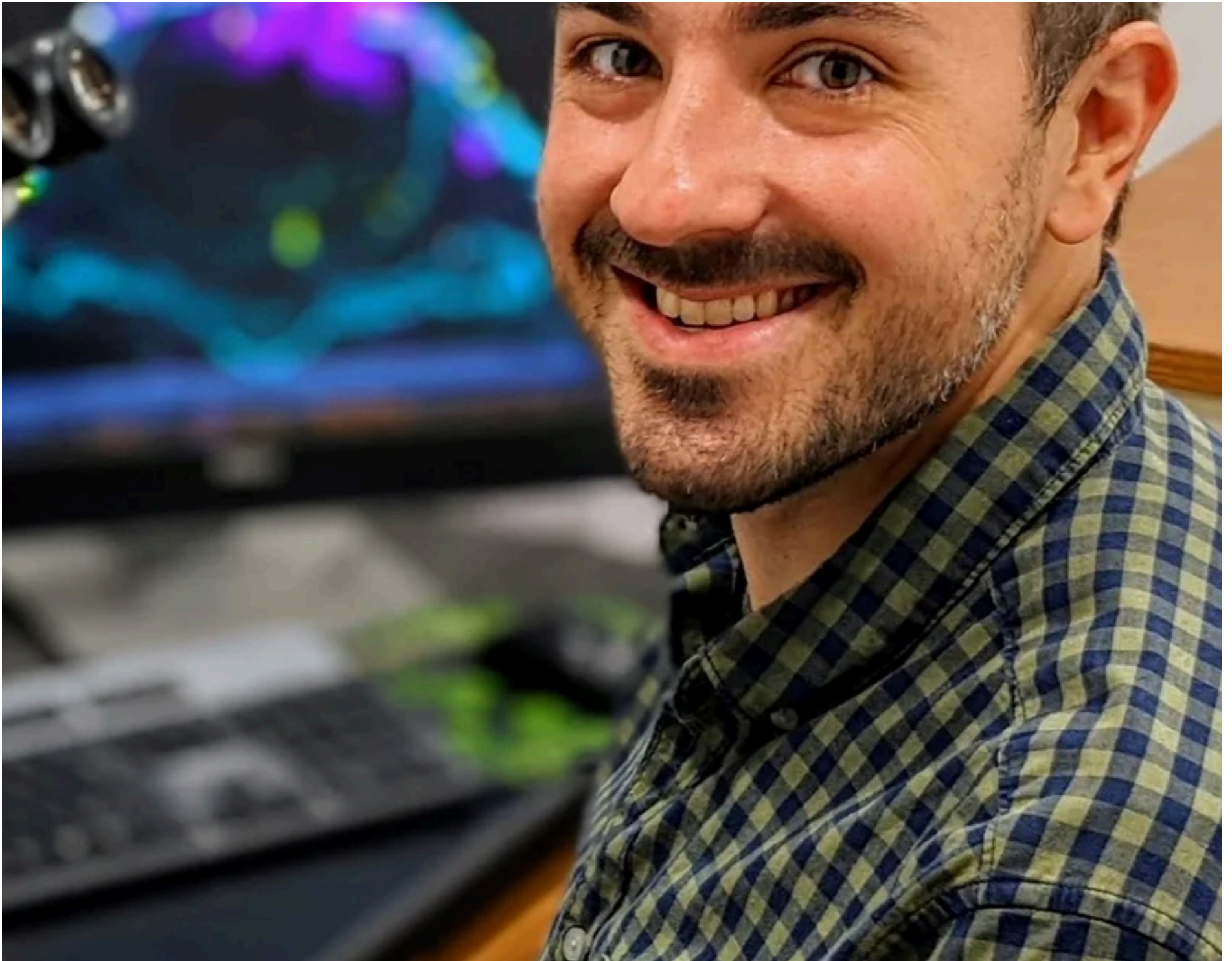
—THE—
PIACENTINO
—LAB—

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Meet the Lab







Mike Piacentino, PhD

he/him/his | PI*michaelpiacentino [at] jhmi [dot] edu*

Mike is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Cell Biology at the Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine. Mike received his PhD from Boston University where he studied skeletal patterning in sea urchin embryos. He fell in love with neural crest cells and chick embryology as a postdoc with Marianne Bronner at Caltech, sparking his interests in lipid metabolism during cell migration.

Mike can't wait to unlock the mysteries of the neural crest cell membrane. Outside of lab Mike enjoys going hikes, mastering new recipes in the kitchen, and fiber crafts like knitting and crochet!







Allison Mancini, PhD

she/her/her | Postdoctoral Fellow

Alli earned her PhD in Molecular Medicine at the University of Maryland School of Medicine working under Dr. Megan Rizzo. During her doctoral work she developed novel fluorescent biosensors, determined how calcium activates RhoA and Rho-kinase in fibroblasts, and characterized the role of Rho-kinase in collective cell migration. In addition to being deeply passionate about microscopy, Alli is extremely interested in the biophysics of cell migration. She is very excited to start learning about the role of lipids in neural crest development. Outside of the lab she enjoys reading, knitting, live music, and travel.







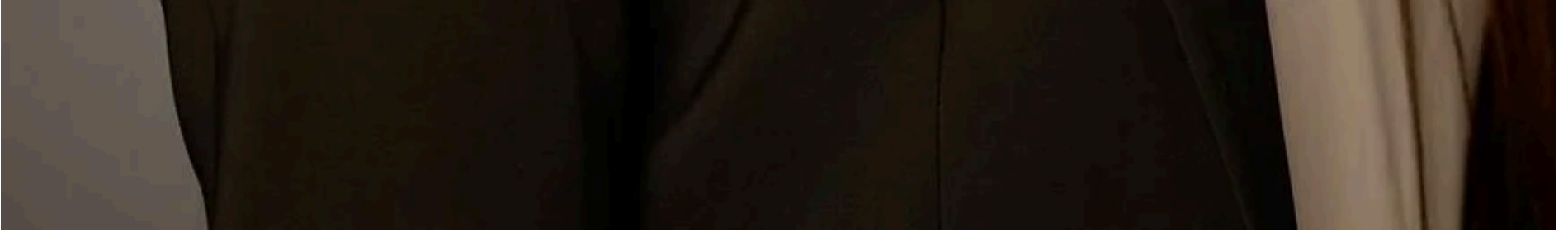
Mallorie Jenne

she/her/her | BCMB PhD Candidate

Mallorie is a PhD candidate in the Biochemistry, Cellular and Molecular Biology program. She earned her BS in Chemistry and Biology from Harvey Mudd College. She previously worked in a research lab under Dr. Jae Hur studying the role of the gene CG5815 in lipid metabolism in fruit flies. She is excited to continue studying lipids in the Piacentino Lab. Outside of lab Mallorie enjoys running, hiking, and looking at plants.







Stephanie Peralta

she/her/hers | BCMB PhD Student

Stephanie obtained her BS in Health Science at Mercy College, where she discovered a passion for being in a laboratory atmosphere. During her undergraduate years, she worked in Dr. Anthony Canger's lab, and her research focused on paxillin and actin expression during neural crest cell migration in chick embryos and retinoic acid as a teratogen in chick CNS development. Stephanie obtained her MS in Biotechnology with a concentration in Biodefense at Johns Hopkins University. She is very excited to start working with chick embryos again and circle back to what made her initially fall in love with working in a laboratory. Outside of the lab, Stephanie enjoys cooking, hiking, reading, and watching sunsets.







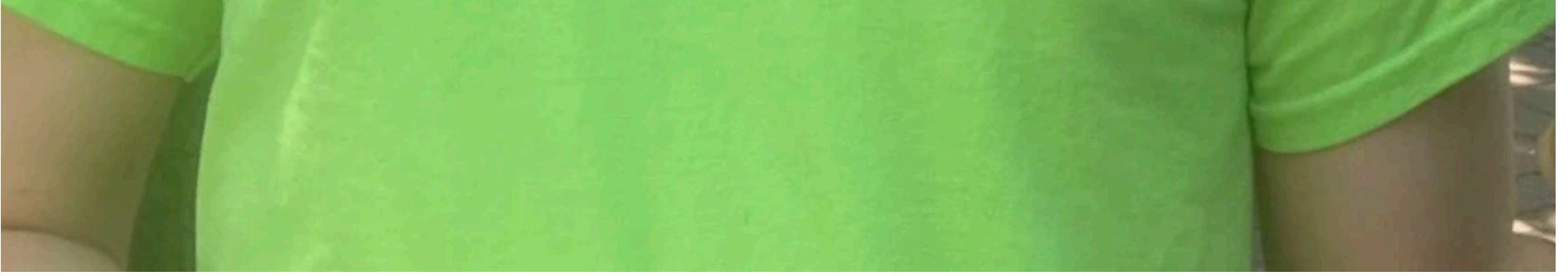
Tristan Oper

he/him/his | Research Technologist

Tristan obtained a BS in Biochemistry and Psychology from the University of New Mexico where he developed a passion for biomedical research while working in a lab under Dr. Curt Hines. Tristan spent four years investigating the role of pericytes in maintaining breast tissue homeostasis and their contributions to tumor development. Tristan is excited to explore more about how lipid organization influences EMT within the neural crest. Outside of the lab, Tristan enjoys many hobbies including video editing, chess, dungeons and dragons, and skiing.







Alex Pomper

he/him/his | Undergraduate Researcher

Alex is an undergraduate at Johns Hopkins University studying Molecular Cellular Biology and History of Science and Technology with a minor in computer science. He's excited to be joining the lab and learning about the neural crest and about lab techniques. In his spare time, Alex likes reading, watching movies, cooking, and playing on the Johns Hopkins squash team.





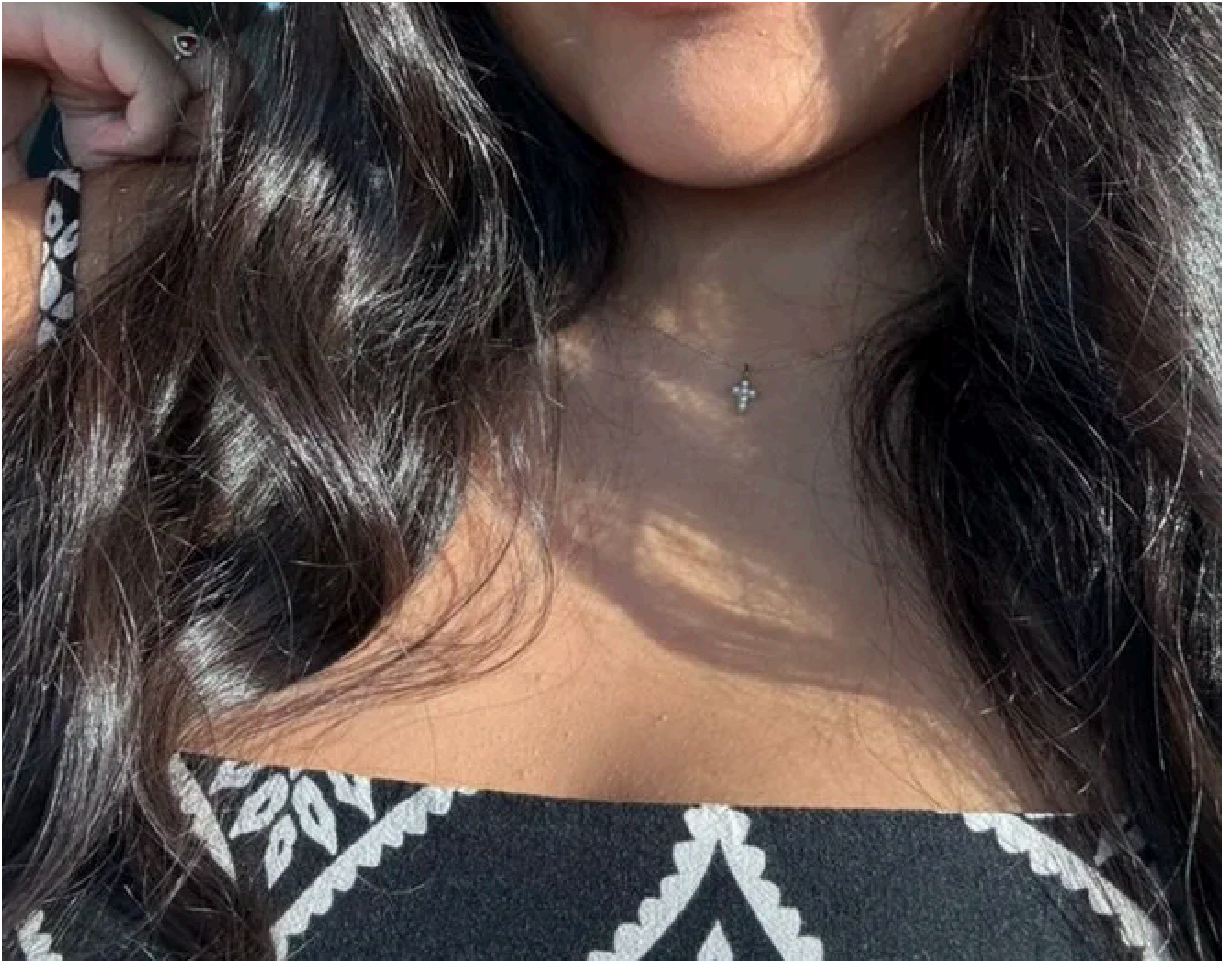


Joyce Chen

she/her/hers | Undergraduate Researcher

Joyce is an undergraduate at Johns Hopkins University majoring in Molecular and Cellular Biology with a minor in Writing Seminars. She is excited to explore the role of lipids in embryonic development and to learn more about imaging with fluorescence microscopy. Outside of the lab, Joyce enjoys reading and writing poetry, going to the gym, and spending time at the beach.







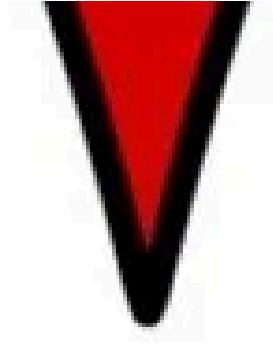
Adriana Vigo

she/her/hers | SARE Program Intern

Adriana participated in the SARE program during the summer of 2024, interning under her mentor Alli Mancini. Through this experience, she gained hands-on research experience and developed a deep fascination with neural crest cell biology and migration. She loves anything biology and is particularly passionate about developmental biology and cell migration research. Adriana is excited about the potential to continue studying the neural crest and further develop her research skills, as her summer work in the Piacentino lab sparked a strong interest in pursuing biomedical research. She's currently a senior in high school and is considering majoring in biology or a related field in college to continue exploring her passion for research. Outside of the lab, Adriana enjoys spending time outdoors, photography, and baking with her family.







You!

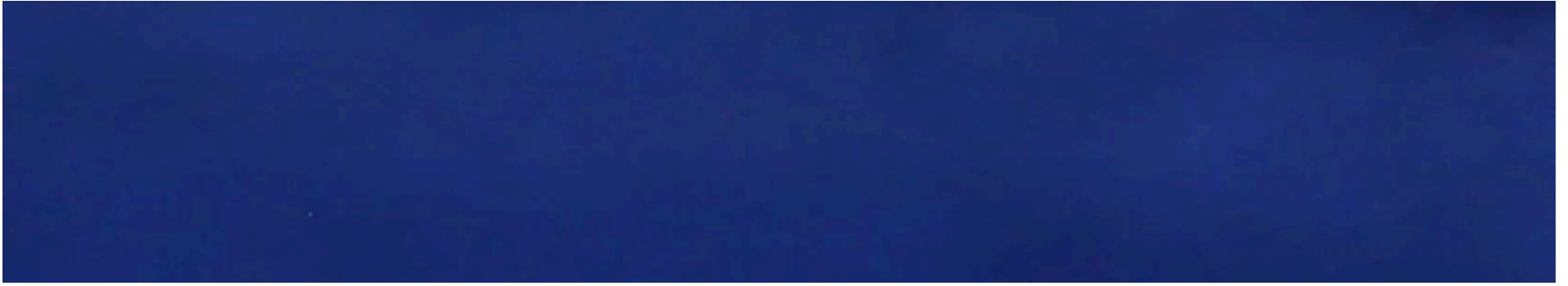
Your pronouns | Your position

We are looking for passionate graduate students, undergraduate students, and postdoctoral fellows to join our team – Please email us to inquire about a position!

Graduate Students – If you are looking for an outstanding PhD program, check out [BCMB @ Hopkins!](#)







Lab Alumni

Bruce Dong (CMM Rotation, 2026)

Monique Lawson (BMB Rotation, 2026)

Yifei Chen (BMB Rotation, 2026)

Danielle Fei (BMB Rotation, 2025)

Natalia Maiorana (MCB Undergraduate Researcher, 2023–2025)

Ilya Grabylnikov (Research Technologist, 2023–2025)

Noah Gurley (BCMB Rotation, 2024)

Madison Shields (SARE Scholar, Summer 2024)

Megan Butler (BCMB Rotation, 2023)

Sydney Pettit (BCMB Rotation, 2023)

Contact the Piacentino Lab

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